okayed it? Based on my report, those responsible for the lapse were taken to task, and the vehicles introduced into service after due rectification.

We were asked by the UN to deploy an infantry brigade in Somalia in August 1993, when the US forces suffered heavy casualties and were deinducted. Initially we were able to stabilize the situation, but the conflict between two rebel factions began to worsen by the day. Our forces were fired upon a number of times and we suffered a few casualties. The UN asked us to do contingency planning for the worst-case scenario of extrication of our forces by a fighting withdrawal. I realized that we could not do so unless the operational and logistics staff from the Army HQ and the air force had an opportunity to familiarize themselves with the area and the operational situation. Hence, I proposed to Lieutenant General V. Oberoi, director general of military operations (DGMO), that we fly to Somalia, study the ground situation and then finalize the plan. The air force readily agreed and our team, led by the DGMO, flew via Muscat (a refuelling halt) to Mogadishu, the war-torn capital of Somalia. In fact, Air Marshal Jimmy Bhatia flew the plane himself. We were briefed at the UN Mission located there. From there we flew to Baidoa, the location of our Brigade HQ. We were briefed by the brigade commander and discussed various options, including evacuation by sea from Kismaayo or, in the worst case, moving through Kenya and embarking from Mombasa. An attempt had been made to simulate a war-zone effect while we were being briefed. But the small-arms and machine-gun firing pattern had no semblance to an actual encounter or a skirmish.

The put-on act failed to impress me. I was accommodated for the night in an EME workshop, because I am an EME brat. Everyone lived in tents there. We had a pleasant evening in the brigade officers' mess. During this period, Indian naval ships also came up till Kismaayo. Thereafter, we flew back via Nairobi, where we had discussions at the highest level with the Kenyan armed forces and civilian officials. They were most supportive, and assured us of all